



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Classical Charter Schools of Southport
School Website: <https://ccssouthport.net/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Classical Charter Schools of Southport NC 28422 (CCS-Southport) presents a public, tuition-free K–8 program that markets itself as a classical charter school with a strong emphasis on direct instruction, structured classrooms, and a “premier performance-driven year-round” approach. Public-facing materials emphasize a replicated network of model schools, open enrollment, a year-round schedule, direct instruction, and a focus on discipline, routines, and a high-quality teaching staff. While the school clearly foregrounds formation of character and moral growth in places (e.g., “moral growth” in statements about what the school hopes to accomplish), the publicly visible materials do not consistently articulate the core classical lexicon (great books, Great Conversation, Seven Liberal Arts, Socratic dialogue, scholé, or explicit emphasis on mastery of transcendentals). Taken as a whole, the evaluation falls between SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL and NOT CLASSICAL in certain categories, with Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal) and Element 5 (Faculty) showing clearer alignments to classical aims, while Categories 1, 3, and 4 show substantial gaps relative to a fully classical program. The aggregate classification is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key insights: - Evidence of classical orientation exists in spirit: a replication model with a long-standing network, emphasis on moral growth, and a focus on rigorous teacher quality. This aligns with some classical aims around formation and a serious, discipline-led pedagogy (Categories 2 and 5). - There is limited explicit public articulation of core classical curriculum elements (Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, Great Conversation) and of Socratic pedagogy, which constrains a full CLASSICAL rating in Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy). - The school’s explicit DI (Direct Instruction) approach, while robust and evidence-based for certain outcomes, diverges from the traditional classical pedagogy emphasis on Socratic dialogue, memory work, and contemplative study in several grade bands. - Faculty rhetoric around “moral growth” and “highest quality teaching staff” is consistent with classical aims around mentorship and virtue, placing Element 5 toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, though the site stops short of a fully developed “living curriculum” portrait. - Parental involvement and community partnership are present, but the public materials do not consistently foreground parents as co-educators or provide structured pathways (books, gatherings, or explicit family formation) in the way classical lexicons describe. This yields a category rating toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Element 6.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials do not articulate transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgical practices, or communal worship as central to the education. The Admissions and Overview pages emphasize replication, open enrollment, and a “premier performance-driven year-round school” rather than theological or liturgical commitments.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Essential Elements lexicon for this category (e.g., theology, liturgy, sacred, transcendentals) are not evident in CCS-Southport’s public content. - Negative keywords indicating secular or non-religious framing are not overtly present either, but their

absence is the point here given the rubric. (Cited framework: Six Essential Elements vocabulary in the knowledge base.)

Why this rating - The school shows no explicit religious/metaphysical foundations or liturgical practices in its public-facing materials. In classical rubric terms, the absence of grounded theology, liturgical life, or transcendental aims places Element 1 in NOT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Explicitly articulate a religious or metaphysical foundation (if permissible within their charter framework) or clearly communicate a transcendently oriented aim (e.g., truth, goodness, beauty with an intentional formation of character through a shared vision). Alternatively, provide a formal rationale for a secular classical approach that still centers the moral imagination and universal truths in line with traditional classical aims. This would push Element 1 toward CLASSICAL or, at minimum, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL if paired with other signs.

Citations - Admissions and overview content show the school's replicated, non-theological framing. - Classical-education keyword framework (theoretical basis) in the knowledge base.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize formation of character and moral growth in service of education, with phrases like “moral growth” and “formation” within the school's narrative. The Overview mentions “moral growth” as a guiding outcome, indicating orientation toward virtues beyond rote information. - Public materials also emphasize a replicated, tradition-like model (Leland/Whiteville) and a focus on a “premier performance-driven year-round school,” which aligns with some classical aims but is framed in a modern performance context. - The NC School Report Card materials note literacy in Latin, Cursive, and Grammar as part of the network's program (a nod to traditional classical elements), even though this is framed within the Roger Bacon network rather than a verbatim Great Books program.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords aligned with formation and virtue: formation, moral growth, moral imagination (concepts from the classical lexicon). The site uses “moral growth” and “formation” language, which maps onto Positive Keywords in the Six Elements lexicon (Formation of Affections; Cultivation of Wisdom and Virtue). - No substantive Negative keywords indicating a lack of formation are present in the public materials.

Why this rating - The school clearly prioritizes formation and moral development (formation/moral growth) rather than purely information-transfer; however, the explicit articulation of virtue-centered aims (and the depth of that formation) is not as robust as canonical classical-language statements (e.g., “pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty” with full articulation of telos). Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is warranted.

What would move the needle - More explicit articulation of a classical telos (truth, goodness, beauty) as the core aim of education, with direct statements about formation beyond information, and a clearly stated aim toward human flourishing and liberal-arts-informed formation. - Add explicit reference to Great Books, classical canons, and a stated objective of the liberal-arts-based formation to further elevate toward CLASSICAL.

Citations - Public materials referencing moral growth and formation. - Latin, Cursive, Grammar as part of the network's curriculum (supporting traditional elements) in the NC School Card materials. - Classical-education formation framework.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site's publicly visible curriculum emphasizes direct instruction, structured classrooms, and year-round scheduling; there is limited explicit mention of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books, or the Great Conversation. There is no clear, explicit statement that Great Books or the Great Conversation are central to the curriculum. - The publicly visible materials highlight a replicated program across CCS campuses and a strong emphasis on direct instruction, rather than a canonical classical curriculum rooted in liberal arts and primary texts. - The NC School Card materials note emphasis on Latin,

Cursive, and Grammar within the broader CCS network, which is a traditional element but does not by itself constitute a full classical curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical curriculum lexicon (Seven Liberal Arts; Great Books; Great Conversation) are not evidenced in the site's public materials. The site does not present Great Books or a Trivium/Quadrivium-centered curriculum; thus, there are zero direct matches to Positive Keywords for this category. - Negative keywords signaling a deviation from classical curriculum (e.g., "social studies-centric history," project-based learning dominance) are not explicitly present; however, the absence of classical curriculum terms is the salient point.

Why this rating - Absence of explicit classical curriculum elements (Great Books, Seven Liberal Arts, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Conversation) places Element 3 firmly in NOT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Public articulation of a classical curriculum blueprint: explicit inclusion of Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium) and Great Books/Great Conversation; inclusion of memorization/recitation (chanting, memory work) and canonical historical-literary texts; cross-disciplinary integration that mirrors classic models.

Citations - Admissions content showing DI-focused curriculum rather than classical liberal-arts emphasis. - NC School Card materials noting a curriculum of Latin, Cursive, Grammar but not a full Great Books framework. - Classical curriculum lexicon context for what constitutes a classical curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize Direct Instruction as the core pedagogy (e.g., "small, direct instruction setting," "frequent assessment to ensure mastery"). This DI emphasis diverges from the Socratic dialogue and scholé-centric practices central to classical pedagogy. - The school's public materials discuss a year-round schedule and structured environments but do not showcase the typical classical-pedagogy features like Socratic seminars, contemplation, or memorization/recitation as core methods in lower or upper grades. The blog content and admissions copy emphasize DI and direct instruction rather than classical seminar formats.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive/Classical Pedagogy keywords (e.g., Socratic dialogue, drilling, memorization, recitation, scholé, memory work) are not evidenced in the public materials; DI-based language is predominant. - Negative keywords indicating DI dominance (e.g., "lecture-based instruction," "rote learning," "teacher-centered instruction") are not explicitly stated as negative in the materials; however, the absence of classical-pedagogy markers counts against a CLASSICAL rating.

Why this rating - The explicit use of Direct Instruction and absence of public-facing Socratic, recitation, or memory-work pedagogy positions Element 4 in NOT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Introduce classical pedagogy components publicly: Socratic discussions in suitable grade bands, recitation/memorization routines (chanting or memory work), copywork or imitation-based exercises, and a policy that foregrounds contemplative learning (scholé) in appropriate cycles. - Provide teacher professional development in classical pedagogy and publish a public outline of the pedagogical approach across K–8.

Citations - Direct Instruction emphasis in admissions/overview materials. - Public-facing reference to classical pedagogy elements not present (lexicon context).

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site emphasizes "Highest Quality Teaching Staff" and that the staff guide students to academic success and moral growth, indicating a value placed on teacher quality and mentorship. This aligns with the classical aim that the faculty serve as living exemplars and mentors. - The site references a faculty community (e.g., headmasters, staff) in various posts, but there is not an explicit, public "living curriculum portrait" of teachers or a formal teacher-portrait framework beyond the stated criteria.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon relevant to this category include: virtuous educators, role models, mentorship, living curriculum, teacher as exemplar, moral formation. The site's language about high-quality teaching staff and moral growth resonates with these ideas, though it stops short of a fully developed "portrait of a teacher" public-facing articulation. - No explicit negative keywords suggesting poor or misaligned faculty practices appear in public content.

Why this rating - There is clear emphasis on quality teachers and mentorship, but the site does not present a fully explicit classical-faculty portrait or a fully developed "living curriculum" concept in public materials. This warrants SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Publish a formal faculty portrait and living-curriculum concept, including teacher professional development in classical pedagogy, and articulating how teachers model virtue and classical habits in daily practice.

Citations - Overarching language about "Highest Quality Teaching Staff" and moral growth. - Classical-faculty framework terms in the knowledge-base lexicon.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - CCS-Southport materials show involvement with families and the broader CCS-America network, including parent-related forms (Parent/Student Handbook, Discipline Plan, On-line Addendum) accessible via admissions pages, and public-facing content referencing community events and school communications. This indicates some partnership with families, though not necessarily a robust public-facing "co-educator" model. - Public materials emphasize a family/community orientation through school events and communications, yet lack explicit, recurring programs centered on parent formation, book studies, or a formal family-liaison role in the curriculum. The publicly visible materials do not consistently promote parents as co-teachers in the classical sense.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords from the Six Elements lexicon for this category include: Partnership with Families; Parent formation; Family catechesis; School-parent synergy; Open campus; Parents as co-teachers. The site does show some parent-focused materials (handbooks) and open access to content, which touches on partnership, but does not clearly present a robust, ongoing "co-teaching" or family-formation program. This yields a modest presence of positive indicators, with limited explicit co-teaching structures. - There are no explicit negative signals about parental involvement in public materials; however, the lack of explicit, sustained co-educator programming reduces the strength of the category signal.

Why this rating - SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL seems appropriate given the partial alignment to family partnership practices and access to parent resources, but the site does not present a deeply formalized parent-education or co-educator framework that classical lexicon would expect.

What would move the needle - Publicly articulate and implement structured family-formation programs (e.g., Classical book clubs, parent-learning cohorts, family liturgies or tradition-formation activities, regular on-site visits, and explicit parental co-teaching roles). - Create and publish a formal "Partnership with Families" protocol aligned with classical education values (home-learning rhythms, family catechesis, and shared mission statements).

Citations - Admissions page with Parent/Student Handbook and related resources. - Classical education family-partnership framework in the knowledge-base lexicon.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Overall Aggregate Ranking: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle (high-leverage, concrete steps) - Curriculum reform and signaling: - Publicly articulate a Seven Liberal Arts-based curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric; arithmetic/geometry/music/astronomy) and the Great Books/Great Conversation framework, with a clear plan for incorporation across grades. - Introduce and publish a plan for classical memory work, recitation, and chant in lower/middle grades (Scholastic-inspired practices) aligned with a rest-filled pedagogical rhythm. - Implement Socratic seminar-style pedagogy in appropriate grade bands, with teacher training to sustain a living dialogue culture. - Pedagogy and practice: - Shift or supplement Direct Instruction with structured classical-pedagogy components (Socratic discussions, guided inquiry, rhetoric training, public speaking opportunities in upper grades). - Publish a public, detailed "Pedagogy Map" showing how classical methods are integrated across K–8, including how memory work, copywork, and imitation-based strategies support mastery. - Faculty development: - Develop and publish a formal "portrait of the teacher" and a living-curriculum framework that describes how faculty model virtue, wisdom, and classical habits, with ongoing professional development in classical pedagogy. - Parental partnership: - Create a robust, public-facing parent-formation program (book studies, classical-family routines, and parent co-teaching opportunities) and formalize a "Partnership with Families" policy with measurable outcomes.

Citations and anchors - The CCS-Southport site demonstrates direct-instruction pedagogy and a defined, structured approach, which is a core barrier to CLASSICAL alignment in Pedagogy (Element 4). - Positive formation language (moral growth, formation) is present in the school's messaging, supporting a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL orientation in Element 2 and Element 5. - The classical-education keyword framework provides the lens for judging presence/absence of Great Books, liberal arts, and Socratic pedagogy. - The NC School Card materials showing Latin/Cursive/Grammar as part of the program provide a signal toward some classical elements, but not a complete classical curriculum.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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